side of this fight is not hurt or self-recrimination, it's a different feeling. For the couple of hours that we dovetailed, locked in a runless battle, we demonstrated something particular about the art of Test cricket with both bat and ball and though he had got through somehow, I felt a kinship and sense of completion with someone from the other side of the world who was also prepared to go to the same lengths and depths for the game.

Two weeks later, immediately after the third Test of the series at Trent Bridge, Alastair Cook asks if he can speak to me. He has decided to retire at the end of this series, he says. It's taken too much out of him – all the mental challenges of having to live with thinking about Test cricket off the pitch, the time he has to put into captaincy, the out-of-form periods that come with constant scrutiny and critique, the energy that the game has required – it all feels like he's lost that tiny edge that is required and he wants to go on his own terms. He says that he's telling me first because I'm his best friend in the team and he wants to see how it feels coming out of his mouth. It feels right, he says. It's been 12 years since that plane journey when we first sat next to each other and he uttered the immortal words, 'The last time we met, you called me a c**t.' I don't think either of us would have believed we would have been on the balcony of Trent Bridge 12 years later, as best mates and the senior members of the England Test team for some time, sharing this moment. He will announce it before the last Test but until then, we keep it to ourselves.

In Alastair Cook's last ever innings for England, he scores a hundred at The Oval. Cricket fans from inside South London and beyond watch on, awestruck and emotional, wider memories of the time spent and all of the lives lived watching Cooky make cricket work for him. I feel like for all the time we have spent together, all the hours upon hours he has stacked up, maybe I've watched him the least. Just like at Brisbane in 2010/11, when we were both top of the world in our respective disciplines, I fall asleep during his innings. Some would say it was a damning appraisal of his batting that I would rather be in the back of the dressing room fast asleep than watching it. The other way you could look at it is that it was all safe when he was batting. There was no alarm. Sleeping was a safe bet. I am not woken by any of the applause that wraps itself around The Oval for minutes as he brings up his hundred, the only person in England sleeping through it.